



IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Electoral reform

BEFORE

1832 Mary Smith presents the first petition to the UK Parliament calling for women to be able to vote in local elections.

1893 New Zealand becomes the first country to give women the right to vote in parliamentary elections.

1894 The Local Government Act in the UK allows women to vote in county and borough elections.

AFTER

1920 The United States gives all women the right to vote.

1928 Universal suffrage in the UK is finally granted to all men and women aged over 21.

2015 Women in Saudi Arabia are granted the right to vote.

POWER IS THE BALLOT

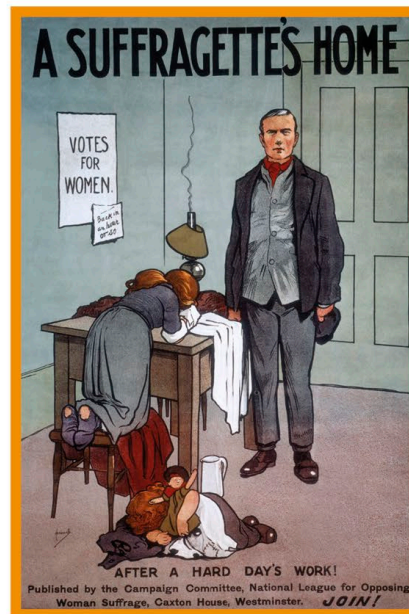
THE REPRESENTATION OF THE PEOPLE ACT (1918)

Before 1832, only 3 percent of Britain's adult male population were entitled to vote. The law granted suffrage (the right to vote) only to men who earned a certain amount of money or held a large amount of property. As Parliament began slowly extending the franchise (the vote) to a larger proportion of the male population (with Acts passed in 1832, 1867, and 1884), women were questioning why they could not

vote. Many men—as well as some women—were hostile toward the idea of women's suffrage, believing that women were too emotional to make rational political decisions and that they didn't know about industry or commerce.

Deeds not words

Female campaigners started to organize themselves into groups. Some activists such as Millicent Fawcett, who formed the National Union of Women's Suffrage Societies (NUWSS) in 1897, believed in peaceful protest, using pamphlets, rallies, and petitions to Parliament to demand the vote. In contrast, Emmeline Pankhurst and the Women's Social and Political Union (WSPU, formed in 1903), with the motto "Deeds not words," favored direct action: vandalism, hunger strikes, and chaining themselves to railings. The impetus for change was further crystallized by the Married Woman's Property Acts of 1870, 1882, and 1884, which



This anti-suffrage poster shows a husband arriving home after a hard day's work to find his tearful children left on their own while the mother is out campaigning.